

Understanding Job Stress, Job Dissatisfaction, and Worker Burnout

INTRODUCTION

This chapter discusses three main issues related to work-related problems: job stress and the reasons behind it, worker dissatisfaction and the many personal and work-related reasons people become unhappy at work, and worker burnout and the many signs that workers are beginning to develop symptoms of depression on the job. Additionally, the chapter provides several personal reflections by workers with job stress and burnout. Finally, the chapter includes major instruments to measure all three issues and, by way of understanding what the instruments measure, the chapter includes a discussion of intrinsic and extrinsic factors in job satisfaction and considers three main theories of management leadership and their potential impact on stress, job satisfaction, and burnout: Theories X, Y, and Z.

JOB STRESS

The National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH) defines job stress as “the harmful physical and emotional responses that occur when the requirements of the job do not match the capabilities, resources, or needs of the worker” (NIOSH, 1999, p. 1). Job stress is sometimes confused with job challenge, but challenge energizes us emotionally and physically and motivates us. When we master a challenge, we are often satisfied with our work. Job stress, on the other hand, has harmful physical and emotional consequences when not handled well or when it is difficult to change because workers have no control over it. The NIOSH report (p. 5) offers the following job conditions as ones that may lead to stress:

- **The design of tasks:** Heavy workload, infrequent rest breaks, long work hours and shiftwork; hectic and routine tasks that have little inherent meaning, do not utilize workers’ skills, and provide little sense of control.

- **Management style:** Lack of participation by workers in decision-making, poor communication in the organization, lack of family-friendly policies. (Chapters 8 and 9 of this book propose approaches to management intended to reduce worker stress.)
- **Interpersonal relationships:** Poor social environment and lack of support or help from co-workers and supervisors.
- **Work roles:** Conflicting or uncertain job expectations, too much responsibility, too many “hats to wear.”
- **Career concerns:** Job insecurity and lack of opportunity for growth, advancement, or promotion; rapid changes for which workers are unprepared.
- **Environmental conditions:** Unpleasant or dangerous physical conditions such as crowding, noise, air pollution, or ergonomic problems. [Storey and Billingham \(2001\)](#) have a similar but slightly different idea of what produces workplace stress and suggest the following potential conditions in the workplace that may lead to stress:

- **The physical climate of a workplace:** Poor working conditions can cause stress. This may include overcrowding, unbearable levels of noise, immoderate temperatures in a building, long commutes to get to work, unsafe conditions on the job, poorly built or uncomfortable office space, and smells that can be offensive.
- **The worker’s role in the organization:** Four factors influence role issues: role conflict or incompatibility between one’s values and beliefs and those of the organization; uncertainty about duties and responsibilities; too much to accomplish and too little time to do it; an expectation that work must be done which is beyond a worker’s level of ability.
- **Work relationships:** Because human service work often takes place in a team context, teams provide both relief from stress and an increase in stress because teams are not always supportive of individual colleagues.
- **Organizational structure and climate:** The extent to which a worker can be involved in and influence decision-making processes can have a significant positive or negative effect. All too often organizations make changes without consulting workers and face morale problems as a result. Asking workers to take on more decision-making for the organization than they can handle also has potential for increasing stress.
- **The impact of one’s personal life on work and the interface between work and home:** Workers are affected by their jobs when stress becomes high. Similarly, their work is affected when personal problems seep over into the workplace. Marital and relationship

problems, financial difficulties, substance abuse and health problems can all negatively affect work and increase stress.

Karasek (1979) found that two work-related elements contribute to job stress: the demands of the job and how much freedom workers have to meet those demands. If job demands are high and freedom to resolve those demands in ways that fit an individual's coping style is low, workers experience high job strain. Beehr (1995) found that ambiguous work assignments and conflict with others are additional reasons for job stress. Sutherland and Cooper (1988) report that job stress substantially increases with the existence of job insecurity, under-promotions, over-promotions, and hindered ambition.

Personal problems that are not connected to work can also add to work stress. These include marital and relationship issues untreated depression and anxiety, other more serious mental health conditions, substance abuse, undiagnosed medical problems, anger issues (which are discussed in greater detail in the chapter on workplace violence), deep insecurities that affect performance and relationship with others on the job, and a number of other issues that can impact job performance. In the chapter on treatment, we will include treatment suggestions for all three conditions: stress, job unhappiness, and burnout.

The University of Massachusetts, Lowell ([U. Mass. Lowell Center for the Promotion of Health in the New England Workplace, 2012, p. 1](#)) reports that studies indicate a strong relationship between workplace stress and the development of cardiovascular problems such as hypertension and myocardial infarction. The report notes that "... up to 23 percent of heart disease related deaths per year could be prevented if the levels of job strain in the most stressful occupations were reduced to average levels seen in other occupations" (p. 1). The report explains that work stressors can trigger cardiovascular disease (CVD) and other chronic health problems and points to three main areas of the body:

- Changes in physiological processes that increase the risk for CVD—high cholesterol, high blood pressure, high blood sugar, weakened immune response, high cortisol, and changes in appetite and digestive patterns;
- Changes in behavior that increase the risk for CVD—low physical activity levels, excessive coffee consumption, smoking, poor dietary habits.
- Development of mental health conditions—anxiety and depression—that independently increase the risk for a range of chronic health conditions, including CVD, obesity, stroke, atherosclerosis, arrhythmias, and myocardial infarction.

The [American Institute of Stress \(2012, p. 1\)](#) reports the following data on workplace stress.

- Sixty-five percent of workers said that workplace stress had caused difficulties, and more than 10% described these as having major effects.
- Ten percent said they work in an atmosphere where physical violence has occurred because of job stress; and, in this group, 42% report that yelling and other verbal abuse is common.
- Twenty-nine percent had yelled at co-workers because of workplace stress, 14% said they work where machinery or equipment has been damaged because of workplace rage, and 2% admitted that they had actually personally struck someone.
- Nineteen percent, or almost one in five, respondents had quit a previous position because of job stress, and nearly one in four have been driven to tears because of workplace stress.
- Sixty-two percent routinely find that they end the day with work-related neck pain, 44% reported stressed-out eyes, 38% complained of hurting hands, and 34% reported difficulty in sleeping because they were too stressed-out.
- Twelve percent had called in sick because of job stress.
- Over half said they often spend 12-hour days on work-related duties, and an equal number frequently skip lunch because of the stress of job demands.

Sometimes stress occurs when you fail to understand underlying issues on a job and how petty jealousies about you and the work you do can lead to very stressful experiences even when your work is at a high level, as this story from a business consultant demonstrates:

A Personal Reflection on Job Stress: A Business Consultant Tries to Help a Family-Owned Business

I am a long time business consultant. Recently, I worked with a mother-daughter team who had successfully created a unique fabric store sewing school. The mother started the business and the daughter stepped in later to try to save it when it began to fail. I was brought in much later to introduce a new product line.

Although I have a friendly relationship with the mother, I primarily report to the daughter, who has turned the business into a profitable and thriving one. Together, the daughter and I developed and launched a new product line. After a very successful sales launch, I was feeling very good about the work I'd done until I got verbally lambasted by the

mother concerning one of the new sewing tools we were launching. She blamed me for creating something that wasn't good for the end-user or the business, and said that I had to live with myself hurting a business she had put so much time and effort into creating. She, in essence, threw a temper tantrum. It turns out she is extremely jealous of her daughter and her accomplishments. Because she could see how successful the new products would be, all that jealousy surfaced and I was in the firing line.

Often the success of a business leads to jealousies and pettiness that I'm never aware of until it surfaces. We somehow have the illusion that families who work together support each other but, quite often, that's not the case. I find that people often torpedo my best efforts even when it leads to successful business ventures because I haven't understood that, all along, they often have deep resentment toward me because their failure becomes my success. That's one of the biggest stressors in my work. I still replay in my mind the mother accusing me of ruining the business and now I have second thoughts about new situations and wonder whether there is something going on that I'm not aware of that will end up in a stressful and hurtful confrontation or, an attempt to undermine everything I've done to help the business.

JOB DISSATISFACTION

When job stress becomes increasingly difficult to control, it often leads to job dissatisfaction. The most commonly used definition of job satisfaction is given by [Locke \(1975\)](#) who defined it as "... a pleasurable or positive emotional state resulting from the appraisal of one's job or job experiences" (p. 1304). This definition implies that not only do we evaluate satisfaction as an emotional state but that we think about those aspects of the job that make us satisfied and dissatisfied.

Morale refers to how a worker appraises the work experience in the future. It's possible for a worker to have good job satisfaction with a current position but to have their morale affected because of future perceptions of the job. A worker may feel that they've learned as much as they can about a job and that to continue doing it will result in boredom or to feel that future salary increases or promotional opportunities are limited.

Early studies of job satisfaction and productivity resulted in very limited evidence to support a relationship between the two. [Iaffaldano & Muchinsky \(1985\)](#) concluded that the relationship was at best trivial, illusory, and nothing more than a management fad. However, more recent research has found these conclusions to be incorrect.

Harrison, Newman, and Roth (2006) reported that low job satisfaction is a very strong predictor of absenteeism, lateness, reduced productivity, high staff turnover, and low morale. These behaviors often have a profound impact on other employees and can be cumulative throughout an organization. Believing that getting rid of an unhappy employee will reduce job dissatisfaction in an organization fails to consider that the open unhappiness of one worker may not take into account other workers who keep their unhappiness to themselves but have all the symptoms and behaviors of job dissatisfaction.

Organ (1988) found that job unhappiness negatively affects organizational citizenship, a behavior that may undermine the morale of others and create organization-wide withdrawal from the extra effort that may be needed to keep the organization functioning during difficult times. Judge, Thoresen, Bono, & Patton (2001) note that job satisfaction is particularly important for professional workers performing complex jobs. Judge and Watanabe (1994) found that job dissatisfaction had a spillover effect and negatively impacted personal life, often resulting in increased levels of depression, minor illness, alcohol and drug use and, in some cases, disrupted domestic relationships and family violence. Although some might argue that spillover has more to do with personal traits of the worker, Wheaton (1990) found that the evidence clearly shows that what workers experience on the job has a clear spillover effect and, when the experience is bad, work may negatively affect mental health.

This is not to say that the job itself is always the reason workers experience job distress and unhappiness. Selecting workers ill-suited for a job, or a mismatch between the worker's personal goals and ways of working with those of the organization, may increase job unhappiness. Key personality traits can also influence job satisfaction. Judge, Bono, and Locke (2000) report that a worker's positive or negative self-evaluation influences job satisfaction, as does extraversion and conscientiousness. Workers with very positive evaluations of themselves and who are also outgoing and conscientious often have high levels of job satisfaction.

Hofstede (1980, 1985) found that the country of origin and culture of a worker often influences their fit within an organization. The researcher said that there were four cross-cultural behaviors that influenced comfort with an organization and work output: (1) whether they view themselves as individuals with distinct needs and aspirations or part of a large whole; (2) their willingness to take risks or just to do what they were told to do; (3) their comfort with a top-down organizational structure or a desire to

have a more equal power distribution, and (4) their passivity or assertiveness in achieving success. For example, [Saari and Judge \(2004\)](#) found that workers in the United States were high on individualism, wanted equality in the workplace, and were high on risk-taking, whereas workers in Mexico were low on individualism, high on the notion of power coming from top management, and low on risk-taking. Keep in mind, however, that as workers assimilate in the United States their work-related behavior becomes more like that of native-born Americans. Nonetheless, it's useful to think that culture and country of origin may affect the way workers view their place in an organization and, consequently, their job satisfaction.

One of the primary reasons for worker unhappiness is explained by the concept of workplace inequity. [Taris, Kalimo, and Schaufeli \(2002\)](#) found that an imbalance in equity, or a feeling that a worker was being treated unfairly, resulted in “emotional exhaustion, cynicism, lack of professional efficacy, sickness, absence, and health complaints” (p. 297). [Adams \(1963, 1965\)](#) believed that people pursue a balance between their work inputs—such as time, attention, skills, and effort—and the rewards of their work, including status, appreciation, gratitude, and pay. According to Adams, any disturbance in that balance will have negative outcomes because workers receive less than what they believe they are entitled to.

WORKER BURNOUT

Tracy's study of workers aboard cruise ships describes burnout as “a general wearing out or alienation from the pressures of work” ([Tracy, 2000](#), p. 6). Burnout is generally thought to be the end result of job dissatisfaction and low morale. To be burned out is not the same as being burned up. Workers who are burned out can have renewing experiences and time-outs that bring back their motivation to work and satisfaction with their jobs. Burned up workers are so depressed and unmotivated with their jobs that it may be difficult or impossible to improve motivation and performance. Burn up happens when burnout goes untreated for too long a period of time. Think of burn up as the final stages of a long-term clinical depression.

[Maslach \(1993\)](#) described three dimensions of worker burnout: (a) emotional exhaustion; (b) depersonalization, defined as a negative attitude towards customers and clients, a personal detachment, or loss of ideals; and (c) reduced personal accomplishment and commitment to the profession. [Farber \(1990\)](#) suggests three types of burned out workers: frenetic,

under-challenged, and worn out. The characteristics of each type are as follows.

- **Frenetic type:** The frenetic type of worker is highly dedicated and committed to their work. Feelings of dissatisfaction cause them to work even harder. Frenetic workers are often tenacious, energetic, and invested in their work and might be considered highly idealistic by most colleagues. Additionally, they are often unable to acknowledge failure, and they set unrealistically high goals for themselves. When those goals are not met, they often feel great negativity about themselves, neglect their own personal needs, and respond to themselves and others with anxiety, irritability, and depression. [Glicken \(2010\)](#) called these workers “idealistic workaholics.”
- **Under-challenged type:** The under-challenged worker has lost interest in his or her occupation and does their work in a superficial way. They have little motivation, see no new challenges, and lack a desire to be more involved on the job. Behaviors associated with the under-challenged worker are indifference, an unwillingness to develop as a person, obsession with finding new jobs and new careers without actually following through, and often complaining about how monotonous the work is and how bored they are.
- **Worn-out type:** The worn-out worker has lost all optimism about his or her job, including even considering other work or new assignments. They have essentially given up, neglected their work-related responsibilities, feel no control over the situation, often feel depressed, and have difficulties performing assigned work tasks. Farber believes that worn-out workers are often the byproducts of inflexible, rigid, bureaucratic organizations where everything is done following arcane rules and procedures no one really knows or understands and that hide the fact that there is unfairness in almost all the decisions made regarding salaries, promotions, and work assignments. Workers at greatest risk of this type of burnout often work in large organizations providing little recognition, support, or appreciation for their work.

[Freudenberger and North \(1985\)](#) believe that burnout often shows itself in the following phases:

1. The need to prove oneself on the job.
2. Taking on increasing amounts of work to the point of work’s becoming a compulsion.
3. Neglecting personal needs.

4. Knowing they are working too hard, beginning to have physical symptoms of overwork, but being unable to do anything about it.
5. Being consumed by work, which leaves them isolated from others.
6. An increase in social isolation, sarcasm with others, and a tendency to blame the work for their increasing sense of isolation.
7. Withdrawal, beginning to use substances to cope, and a tendency to do the job by the book.
8. Obvious behavioral changes noted by others.
9. Behavior at work becoming mechanical and robotic.
10. Inner emptiness and exaggerated activities involving food, substances, and sex.
11. Depression.
12. Physical and emotional collapse.

[Lorenz \(2009, p. 1\)](#) provides the following signs of burnout:

- Crankiness, irritability, and an inability to get along with co-workers you used to get along with just fine;
- Coming to work late, wanting to leave early, dreading coming to work at all, watching the clock, and counting the minutes until you leave;
- A sense of apathy and a lack of motivation; no longer wanting to be challenged;
- No longer interested in interacting socially with co-workers;
- Feeling exhausted much of the time, having headaches, feeling tension in all of your muscles, and having trouble sleeping.

A Personal Reflection on Worker Burnout: A Judge Confronts the Limitations of Her Job

Linda Morgan is a superior court judge in a state in the northeast. She told us that as caseloads have increased and judicial discretion has been taken away from judges because of strict sentencing guidelines handed down by legislatures, many judges are experiencing burnout and retiring early. In her own experience an example she cited was a young man charged with possession of illegal drugs. Should she impose prison time or probation on the son who is taking care of his elderly mother (who sits weepy eyed in the back of the courtroom)? He claims he is going to school to become a nurse. She doubts that he will make it since he was caught with enough marijuana to show that, although he is not a dealer, he is very likely a heavy user. Heavy drug use, she suspects with considerable past experience with drug users, will not bode well for academic work.

The guidelines for the amount of marijuana found in his possession calls for a prison sentence, but who will take care of the elderly mother? If she sentences him to probation, she faces judicial scrutiny and possible sanctions in her appointed job because her decision would be contrary to the guidelines imposed by a strongly anti-drug-use legislature.

She told me that “His face reflected what so many others tell me in their eyes: A pleading to be released, a desire to do better for themselves, if only in this moment. I, of course, have heard it all before. I know of all the jobs that are starting “tomorrow,” of all the children that need them to be “out” so they can provide for their families, and even the ones who just look at me as only a shell of the person they once were. But for today, at this hour, at this time, I believe him and yet I must sentence him to jail time. It eats away at me. I go home and look at the calendar and wonder if I can make it for three more years until I can retire. I’m not sure that I can.”

WAYS OF DETERMINING JOB DISSATISFACTION AND WORKER BURNOUT: THEORIES X, Y, AND Z

There are a number of well-accepted ways to determine job dissatisfaction and worker burnout. The following are a few, and more instruments may be found on the book’s website.

Job Satisfaction

The Job Descriptive Index (JDI; [Smith, Kendall, & Hulin, 1969](#)) is the most frequently used measure. The JDI measure five major factors associated with job satisfaction: the nature of the work itself, compensations and benefits, attitudes towards supervisors, relations with co-workers, and opportunities for promotion. To understand how the JDI and similar instruments can give us an understanding of the level of job satisfaction across all occupations, [Table 2.1](#) shows data reported by [Bryner \(2007\)](#) on a 2006 national study of 27,000 workers conducted at the University of Chicago, which provides, for a range of occupations, the percentage of workers in each occupation who are satisfied with their work.

Intrinsic and Extrinsic Motivators

On average, 47% of all workers surveyed by [Bryner \(2007\)](#) said they were satisfied with their jobs and 33% reported being very happy. [Table 2.1](#) shows that many of the most highly satisfied workers are also only moderately paid (clergy, teachers, authors). The reason for this may have to do

Table 2.1 Percentage of Workers, by Occupation, who are Satisfied with their Work

Occupation	Percent satisfied
The Top 10	
Clergy	87
Firefighters	80
Physical therapists	78
Authors	74
Special education teachers	70
Teachers	69
Education administrators	68
Painters and sculptors	67
Psychologists	67
Security and financial services salespersons	65
Operating engineers	64
Office supervisors	61
The Bottom 10	
Laborers, except construction	21
Apparel clothing salespersons	24
Handpackers and packagers	24
Food preparers	24
Roofers	25
Cashiers	25
Furniture and home-furnishing salespersons	25
Bartenders	26
Freight, stock, and material handlers	26
Waiters and servers	27

Source: Bryner (2007).

with the satisfaction they experience from the work itself rather than the salary and benefits they receive. Herzberg (1973) argued that *intrinsic aspects* of the work (whether the work itself gives you pleasure) leads to being satisfied, while *extrinsic aspects* of the job such as salary and benefits prevent workers from being dissatisfied. In order for salary and benefits to keep workers from being dissatisfied they must regularly increase. Failure to do so leads to job dissatisfaction.

Herzberg's contribution to our understanding of job satisfaction is that the motivation to work hard, and ultimately job satisfaction, comes from within. The organization's task is to utilize workers in ways that facilitate their internal motivation, or the satisfaction derived from the work itself and the contribution they make to the organization. This crucial finding offers management a better way to use people by hiring workers who are

motivated by the work itself rather than assuming workers are only interested in money. The belief that extrinsic factors motivate workers requires management to continually up the ante with increasingly better pay and benefits to get results. During times of economic trouble when added salary and benefits aren't available, in organizations that use money as a motivator, lack of salary increases can precipitate reduced job satisfaction.

Theories X, Y, and Z

Theory X and Y

McGregor (1960) suggested that the use of incentives to motivate workers could best be understood by the leadership style of an organization's managers and suggested two distinct types of leadership styles: Theory X and Theory Y. The Theory X leadership style is very authoritarian and assumes that workers are largely lazy, lacking in motivation, require a high level of supervision to make certain the work gets done, and require substantial salary and benefit incentives to work hard. On the other hand, the Theory Y leadership style assumes that employees are driven, ambitious, and want to accept larger roles within the organization. This leadership style encourages creativity in the workforce based on the belief that productivity increases when employees have the opportunity to face new work-related challenges. This leadership style is often found in workplaces that prize employees who think and use their creative abilities over those who can simply repeat a task. Under Theory X, the leadership style is likely to be autocratic, which may create resistance on the part of workers. Communication flow is downward from manager to the subordinates. Theory Y leadership styles value worker participation and empowerment which, it is hoped, will result in workers seeking more responsibility and commitment to organizational goals.

Theory X has been criticized for being out of touch with workers who have been socialized by a society that values participation and resents punitive practices like the carrot and stick approach used in Theory X (the carrot if you do what you're told to do and the stick if you don't). Theory Y has been criticized because, in the hands of a less than competent manager, it can become chaotic with lines of authority so unclear that nothing gets done. An additional criticism of Theory Y is that it is nothing more than a subtle form of manipulation with management giving workers the illusion of having freedom when actually they don't. Without shared economic benefits for their productivity then, goes the criticism, workers have simply been manipulated into working harder for limited economic benefits.

Theory Z

One additional leadership style that affects motivation to work and job satisfaction is Theory Z (Ouchi, 1981). This theory, also known as the Japanese approach to management, focuses on increasing employee loyalty to the organization by providing a job for life with a strong focus on the well-being of the employee, both on and off the job. According to Ouchi, Theory Z management tends to promote stable employment, high productivity, and high employee morale and satisfaction. Whether this approach can be sustained in difficult economic times is questionable since even Japanese companies have laid workers off and changed their policy of lifetime job security as a result of the poor worldwide economy.

Determining Burnout

The Maslach Burnout Inventory (MBI; Maslach & Jackson, 1986) is the most well accepted and frequently used way of determining burnout. The MBI consists of 22 questions and three subscales which measure interrelated aspects of burnout, including emotional exhaustion (EE), depersonalization, and personal accomplishment. The MBI takes 10–15 minutes to complete; in some busy settings this may lead to either socially desirable answers (answers the test taker thinks are the most positive or negative but do not actually represent his or her true feelings) or answers that are not well thought through. Instead, Hansen (2010) found that asking workers just one question—“Are you emotionally exhausted?”—was as effective in determining burnout as giving the entire instrument. Measures of depression such as the Center for Epidemiologic Studies Depression Scale (CES-D), which is free and can be found on the book website, may be just as good a measure of burnout as the MBI, which can be expensive to give since there is a fee for each copy used.

A concept that is increasingly used in the helping, medical, and teaching professions is compassion fatigue. Compassion fatigue refers to a decline in the ability to experience joy or to feel and care for others, and occurs in professionals who expend a great deal of energy and compassion on others, yet get little positive feedback or inner peace for their labors. Compassion fatigue may also be seen as an extreme form of stress in which the professional begins to experience secondary traumatic stress because of the physical and emotional trauma of taking care of people in dire need.

However, all the surveys and instruments to measure burnout seem less likely to spot it than carefully listening to workers talk about their depressed feelings toward their jobs and observing their behavior, their productivity, and the many signs of burnout mentioned earlier in the chapter. Careful observation and honest discussions could lead to changes in work assignments, strategic timeouts from work, or retraining for new assignments. All of these as well as personal counseling would help to reduce the number of cases in which burnout enters a final stage in which the worker is completely burned up.

Personal Observation: A Worker Confronts the Realization That Her Burnout Stems From an Incorrect Career Choice

Lynn Packer, a former Marriage and Family Counselor from Thousand Oaks, California told us, “I knew I wasn’t suited for a career as a therapist. I’d sit listening to people complain about their problems at work and at home and I’d get up in the morning grumbling that I didn’t want to go to work, arrive late, and leave early. I was one step away from an exit interview”.

“I finally had to admit that I was the problem, not the clients who were pouring their hearts out to me. I was a proponent of ‘just do it’ therapy long before Nike entered the picture. I couldn’t understand why anyone who was so unhappy in their lives just didn’t change it. Finally, I took my own advice and left. I planned my exit. It took over a year before I left and I made sure not to burn any bridges. I applied to law school, got accepted, and I was off to the races. Now, no more waking up to ‘I don’t want to go to work.’ Now it’s ‘did I malpractice yesterday?’ but I’m far happier and more successful at work. I think my early life ideas about a career were influenced by my own personal problems and a belief that helping others would be a way of helping myself. I didn’t realize that once I dealt with those problems, that counseling would bore me”.

“I’m glad I didn’t wait around and become cynical and pessimistic like a lot of people I know who stick with a career way longer than they should. And I have to admit that my training and experience as a counselor have taught me a great deal about human behavior that comes in very handy as a lawyer, so I don’t feel that I wasted my time getting my degree. I do think that you shouldn’t always blame organizations for burnout but you should recognize that people come to jobs with their own issues and that before the next job or the job after that also ends in burnout, you have to be honest with yourself, get the necessary help and change whatever past ways of thinking about work continue to end in burnout.”

SUMMARY

This chapter defines three types of work-related problems that impact a worker's performance: job stress, job dissatisfaction, and worker burnout. It is suggested that the three move in tandem with one another, with job stress leading to job dissatisfaction, and dissatisfaction, unless corrected, leading to burnout. Many researchers believe that burnout is a type of depression that saps motivation to work. All three conditions impact work effectiveness and often intrude into the personal lives of workers. Instruments to measure stress, dissatisfaction, and burnout are provided, but in the case of burnout a simple question asking workers if they are depressed can have the same impact as the use of a burnout instrument. Supervisors observing worker attitudes and performance can often identify all three conditions on the basis of simple behaviors such as tardiness, missing work with vague reasons, decline in the quality and quantity of work, and a thorough lack of enthusiasm. Early research suggesting that unhappy workers had the same level of productivity as happy ones has been thoroughly debunked in later research showing that job unhappiness not only affects productivity but may have a negative impact on health, mental health, and personal and family lives. Several workers gave their personal descriptions of how it feels to have each of the three work-related conditions discussed in the chapter.

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